

Race to Face:

Contact Zones in the Writing Fellow Conference

Tim Scallon

University of Wisconsin-Madison

When students leave for college, they are under the assumption that they will graduate with skills and education to lead successful lives. In reality, the nationwide graduation rate is a humbling 55.5 percent. Yet, minorities face even tougher statistics in a racially and culturally biased education system (HigherEdInfo.org). Such inequality is especially prevalent at the University of Wisconsin-Madison. A 2009 study from the nonprofit organization Education Trust found that UW-Madison suffered large disparities in graduation rates between racial groups. While 82.9 percent of White students graduated from the University within six years, only 73 percent of Latinos and 56.4 percent of Blacks managed to graduate in the same amount of time. A major effort to counteract such alarming statistics centers around initiatives for diversity on a campus that is 78.4 percent White. However, African-American author bell hooks notes in her book Teaching to Transgress that “recent discussions of diversity and multiculturalism tend to downplay or ignore the question of language” (173). Because written communication is a key component to academic and professional success in an increasingly globalized economy, a focus on improving writing skills for all students may be a way to help close the large gap in higher educational success between Whites and minorities in America. Proficiency in writing is of paramount importance in college, the community, and the workforce. In all areas of professional society, “writing is the primary basis upon which your work, your learning, and your intellect will be judged” (Marquette Writing Center website). Related skills, or the lack thereof, frequently have a dramatic impact on student success.

One way for colleges to offer guidance is tutoring through a campus Writing Center. Unfortunately, as Geller et al. noted in their 2007 book *The Everyday Writing*

Center, “racism is an everyday experience for students, tutors, and directors of color,” and such prejudice may unwittingly extend to, and be perpetuated by, white-dominated Writing Centers. Of course, guidance can only be given if students are making ample use of available resources. Rebecca Fremo, director of the Writing Center at Gustavus Adolphus College, found that many minorities bore distrust for the institution, fearing White criticism for “affirmative action,” or being labeled as ESL, in the case of some Hmong students (1). To counteract negative perceptions and eliminate the unintended power differential, her predominantly White tutor program seemed to project; Fremo worked closely with the College's Diversity Center to establish a satellite Writing Center office on unfamiliar turf. Through efforts to dismantle what had been seen as reiteration of White power structure at Gustavus, minority attendance greatly increased (4, 5). In order to actually demonstrate to tutors that the power structure *did* exist, tutors were given a cultural competency test called the Intercultural Development Inventory. Many self-proclaimed “conscious” students found they had been in denial of many cultural differences, and gained opportunity for growth. Even after expanding to the Diversity Center, Fremo was disappointed with the low level of diversity within her own tutor staff (5).

While maintaining a level of diversity representative of the student population may have helped boost interest in the program, Writing Center theorist Frankie Condon writes that tutors should also have a voice in dictating the anti-racist ethos diverse Writing Centers seek, in order to best practice cultural competence (26). Simply being told what to believe is a less effective education tool than allowing the tutors to formulate their own understandings of why certain discourse practices are racist. A new ethic

bridging the “habits, customs, and character” of tutors and tutees should help abolish the self-aggrandizing white assumption that minorities come to Writing Centers to learn from the somehow skilled majority (Fremo, 3) and instead promote diversity as “a state of mind, an ethical code of inclusiveness” (Rihn, 1). Such an ethic promotes consciousness while resisting assumptions about any particular individual student.

In order to establish an ethic of diversity, controversial and uncomfortable issues of prejudice and privilege must be brought to the forefront of discourse. A beneficial discussion of racial and cultural biases requires Writing Centers to assume two seemingly contradictory roles, coined by Mary-Louise Pratt as the “safe house” and the “contact zone.” The safe house suggests an environment where damaging and ethnocentric legacies can be discussed and mutually understood in a trusted setting without fear of retribution (6). In contrast, the contact zone is defined as any of a number of “social spaces where cultures meet, clash, and grapple with each other, often in contexts of highly asymmetrical relations of power” (1). Claims made in the safe house will often clash with other cultures, and may force participants to consciously reflect on uncomfortable discourses and vestiges of institutionalized racism (6). Pratt's envisioned contact zone, however, takes place in the unsheltered real world. While participants may not always be aware of its occurrence, it should expose conflicts often undiscussed, to promote dialogue between varying cultural points of view. Engaging in contact zones can help Writing Center employees and students become more culturally competent while dispelling fears and realities of racism and insensitivity within the institution.

While there is a sizable body of literature on (anti-)racism and the contemporary Writing Center, much less has been written about contact zones in the context of a peer

tutor dynamic. The Writing Fellows Program at UW-Madison, founded in 1997, is designed with the belief that any person, no matter how novice or experienced, can improve their writing with the help of an experienced peer to critique and evaluate the work. Based on a model at Brown University, the Program serves as an extension of the campus Writing Center, granting undergraduate students opportunities to serve their peers as writing tutors. Fellows are assigned to writing-intensive courses, commenting on strengths and weaknesses of student papers before holding individualized conferences to discuss strategies for revision (Writing Fellows website). Unlike Writing Center tutors, who hold degrees, work regular hours, and often hold appointments in semi-private cubicles, Writing Fellows are undergraduate peer tutors who generally have conferences in public places. Although their expertise creates a power differential, they may actually be younger than the students they tutor. Fellows likely have been exposed to less material on tutoring and diversity, and indeed, their introductory seminar course included no teaching of contact zones at the time of publication (Hall). While students typically seek out the Writing Center of their own volition, Writing Fellow conferences are often a mandatory component of class assignments, and participation is frequently factored into final paper grades. Fellows have a unique opportunity to gain a more personal relationship with their students, as peers who will meet more than once over the course of a semester. Because they will interact with students in a setting of greater intimacy, their body language and handling of revision are especially crucial in forging a meaningful and mutually beneficial dynamic with students.

Author's Note

The false notion of “colorblindness” hinders attempts at an honest, productive discussion of the discourses of race, and is only perpetuated if those speaking do not also acknowledge their own backgrounds. As a researcher on the topic of race in the Undergraduate Writing Fellows Program, I would certainly be irresponsible if I omitted any synopsis of my ethnic and economic background to give fair context to my arguments. I am for all practical purposes White, the result of a hodge-podge of intermixed European groups (predominantly Irish, German, and Scandinavian). I come from an upper-middle class family with two professional parents in a stable marriage. Rich Whites like myself are ultimately products, members, and producers of the “culture of power,” Lisa Delpit's term for the realm more widely known as White Privilege. Andrew Rihn notes that “One danger of discussing racism and racial privilege is that many white people become defensive, a reaction which can shut down a tutorial” (1). Because I have been raised within the “culture of power,” my brain is ingrained with the set of rules I need to succeed. Yet, as Delpit predicts, I was and still am often unwilling to acknowledge the existence of my socioeconomic advantage, blaming disparity on others and shrugging off claims that I exercise my power (282). Accepting one's status is an important step in moving towards cultural competence, but is certainly only the beginning.

Research Methods

This paper seeks to examine the social dynamic in the interracial writing conference, analyzing body language and dialogue to determine the prevalence and benefits of engaging in Pratt's “contact zones.” My small case study will utilize a

convenience sample of conferences between Fellows and students not of their race. To help ensure the genuineness of observed contact zones, students were not informed of the study's purpose, merely that it was examining Fellows' interaction with their students. I videotaped and recorded audio of the conferences, later transcribing them. Two Fellows were observed: the first was a male Chinese-born, ESL student, and the second was a White female born in America. Names have been changed to protect participants' identities. The contact zones themselves may be obvious or may go relatively unnoticed to conference participants; indeed, they may be as invisible as the power differentials that necessitate their exploration. Positive student-Fellow engagement in contact zones provides greater mutual understanding, helps to silence racist discourses, and can promote a Writing Center's commitment to diversity awareness.

Results

Through analysis of conference tapes, I have discovered that although contact zones may occur on a small scale, they can be found in numerous conferences across racial groups. While the Fellows I examined were aware that I was scrutinizing their interactions with other races, the contact zones I observed generally took place within the context of the Fellows' suggestions for revision of the students' papers. Because neither Fellows nor students knew exactly what I was looking for within the conference dynamic, the participants were less likely to be influenced by subconscious desires to behave in a manner that might portray them as “more racially conscious” or “less racist”. As I will discuss, knowledge (or lack thereof) that a beneficial contact zone has occurred may play a role in how participants reflect on future interracial conferences. My findings indicate

that both Fellows and the students they are tutoring can benefit from engaging in contact zones, whether they are aware one is occurring or not.

The first conference record I examined was an audio recording of a meeting between Míng, a Chinese-born Fellow who studied two years in a Canadian high school before coming to UW-Madison for higher education, and Stacy, a White undergraduate student. Míng had offered to be a study participant after learning I had difficulty finding Fellows willing to be analyzed in a racial context, and I thank him for helping me consider the advantages in viewing conferences from an ESL Fellow. Since Míng is a minority and not a native English speaker, I had expected the conference's power differential to weigh in Stacy's favor. However, his strong command of the language is immediately apparent, and he does most of the speaking. The beginning of their discussion is focused on weakly defined terms. Examining Stacy's paper, Míng notices vague use of "darkness," a common metaphor in the Western world for connoting negative qualities or undesirability:

Míng- My question is, you mention the darker side of humanity, right? I mean, what do you mean by darker side? Because dark is a color. It cannot give a very concrete idea about what you mean. So you mean obsession with wealth, you mean...?

Stacy- Yeah I would say, sort of, not an obsession with wealth, but like, a personal greed? Míng- Exactly, greed, exactly. There we go. Greed is a better term than darker side... Well, not better, just more concrete. Sorry. (Both share an awkward laugh.)

Here we can see Stacy following the age-old Western discourse of light and dark

as respective symbols for good and evil, assigning darkness to humanity's shortcomings. Ming utilizes his multicultural experience to explain that Stacy can't assume her reader shares the same cultural context for darkness, and must use specific examples instead of vague color symbolism. Stacy has unconsciously associated dark color with greed, and only after Ming prods her to think more deeply about what she means does she move towards a more concrete description. Though her context for darkness is not intentionally or specifically grounded in race, Stacy's assumptions appear to display a learned cultural bias about the color that Ming does not share. Whether or not he is aware at the time of the parallels he is drawing to Western racism, his own experience in the educational systems of three different countries seems to tell him that "darker side" may not be an appropriate, concrete term for her paper, as it is not a universal symbol of morality, but only a color. While it is impossible to guess what either student is thinking, Stacy leaves the conference with the knowledge that her assumptions about darkness are not universal and will not hold up under critique. Because of her small contact zone with her Fellow Ming, she is unlikely to repeat the same mistake in later papers, and will cease to perpetuate the discourse. Though Stacy may be totally oblivious to what she has learned about subtleties in language supporting racism, and isn't likely to change the world on her own, she is an individual beneficially changed by Ming's reasoning.

Although a contact zone can be a very nuanced experience, it can also manifest itself much more obviously to all parties involved. In a different conference between Meredith, a White Writing Fellow, and Liz, a Black student, the topic of race comes up almost immediately:

Liz- So I saw a couple points where you said you were looking for deeper

analysis? It was in the paragraph about race I think?

Meredith- Right.

Liz- So, what you meant by that? Cause like, it's five pages, and I almost feel like I'm stretching it if I try to make it longer...

Meredith- Um, I just felt more that, your other parts, you had a lot of analysis and you really developed them, and your paragraph on race.. I felt like it wasn't quite the same. And so I noticed the difference between that.

Liz- Okay. (Writes down notes)

Meredith- So like, it's a good paragraph, but you could make it more well-rounded. But it's a lot to fit in a five page paper, so...

Liz- So in um, okay so this I get, I reread it and I was like why'd you... But okay, (Looks up at Meredith) just tell what what you feel.

Confronted with the question of why Meredith chose to critique Liz's paragraph on race, both students look up at each other. Meredith treads very lightly, initially only giving a one word response. After the conference concluded, Meredith told me she hadn't wanted Liz to misinterpret her comments as suggestions to dramatically change or get rid of the paragraph entirely, and I wondered if her own knowledge of my study topic had led her to overanalyze Liz's question as accusatory. However, upon viewing the tape I too felt that a misunderstanding was quickly brewing. Liz asks, "So, what you meant by that," a direct question implying she didn't initially grasp *why* her race paragraph might have required deeper analysis. Immediately she goes on to defend herself as following the assignment's limit of five pages, rather than waiting for Meredith's response. Meredith's justification for her comment is delivered slowly, as she searches for the best way to

lightly explain her reasoning. She appears concerned with Liz's curt response of "okay," but is at first unable to formulate any real advice for improvements. Liz's frustration is apparent when she gives Meredith the role of power, bluntly asking her to tell her what she feels about the paragraph. Meredith quickly prompts her to ask her own questions first, and the conversation twice more manages to segue back into race before some common ground is established. To her credit, Meredith does not avoid discussion of race (despite her discomfort), and even though the book Liz is writing about seems to be in actuality more focused on the South's attitudes towards homosexuality, she is patient and interested in how Liz's ideas about race relate to the work. One particularly thought-provoking point in their conference helps illustrate the particular benefits Meredith gains from her contact zone with Liz:

Liz- I said that race is disregarded, and that is a parallel to show the attitudes of how it was during that time in the South. It's also giving that dichotomy..? It's like a separation of 'this is what it is like, this is what was really going on, and this is how people saw it to be.' Is that in any way related to any of my other points?

Meredith- Well, how do you see them as related?

Liz- For example, if you ignore something long enough it'll go away. 'Let's forget about that, we're diminishing it.'

Because race can be so difficult and uncomfortable to talk about, especially for someone who is born into the culture of power, Whites may have the tendency to shy away from the topic to avoid confrontation or accusations of racism. Meredith could have made the (un)conscious decision to not make a comment at all on the quality of Liz's race

paragraph, knowing full well that she risks an awkward scenario. She decides not to “ignore” or “diminish” the race question but rather to bring it to the table with a Black student, desiring to help her improve her paper and her argument. The conference lasts over an hour, holistically far from antagonistic, and is marked by friendly conversation and laughter from student and Fellow alike. Evidently here the two are not dealing with racism's deepest dilemmas or twisted theories, but her effort alone to address the race paragraph as just another important piece of the argument, and her willingness to push forward in its examination, creates a contact zone. Meredith takes a risk but is given an opportunity to practice the necessary sensitivity in talking race with a minority student, and it eventually pays off, creating a very successful conference. Liz, a freshman, leaves the conference happy with a good impression of the Writing Fellows program as an institution that doesn't shy away from race, and as such might recommend it to friends who may be skeptical. It is possible that Meredith's knowledge of my study played a part in influencing her actions in the conference. Yet, her comments were completed and submitted to Liz before I had approached her to conduct research, so it seems she would have been equally likely to at least have recorded her criticisms.

Conclusions

From my observations of writing conferences, I have obtained exploratory data on contact zones, and their manifestation in the interracial Writing Fellow conference. However, I do not have enough information to make generalizations about the behavior of racial groups and their likelihood of engaging in contact zones, and I was unable to observe any conferences where the student was male. According to Claire O'Leary's 2009

study of the gender dynamic in Writing Fellow conferences, “gender performance by students significantly affects a writing fellow's conferencing style,” and it is possible I would have garnered different results from a larger, more sexually heterogeneous research sample. While I was able to observe multiple contact zones, not every conference I examined provided examples. Out of four recorded conferences, only two contained racial contact zones. Clearly the conversation in an interracial conference cannot be inherently *expected* to create such conflict, and sometimes opportunities for contact zones simply do not surface. It is because of their unpredictability and great variation that I advocate including related articles by Pratt and others in Writing Fellow training, so tutors might be better prepared to handle instances of racism or racial misunderstanding in the line of duty.

In the contact zones I witnessed, I was surprised to find that the power dynamic was by no means rigid. While conferences did indeed exhibit an asymmetric power structure between Fellow and student, neither held control for the whole conversation. In the case of Meredith and Liz, the Fellow's consistent attempts to give power to the student were marked by her awareness of her own position as a tutor within the “culture of power.” Liz initially relinquishes power by giving Meredith the floor for criticism, but reassumes control when she is able to fully articulate her reasons for including a paragraph about race in her paper. By deliberately steering the conversation back to the same issue until it is resolved, Liz asserts herself as the owner of her paper and comes to her necessary “deeper analysis” with only minor assistance from Meredith's prodding questions. Before I viewed Míng's conference, I had expected his status as an ESL Fellow to diminish his own power in the face of a native speaker, but he spoke more than Stacy

and offered more suggestions than she asked questions. Whatever power Stacy initially held as a white Westerner was quickly checked by Míng's observations about her vague assumptions. However, Stacy reassumed control in her insistence on producing a good thesis before she left the conference. Because the dynamic of power in a Writing Fellow contact zone is not predictable and can shift, Fellows should be aware of their ability to both guide a productive discussion, and to hinder one.

Contact zones need not always manifest themselves obviously, and awareness of their occurrence may play a part in their effectiveness. When I told Míng about my findings, he said he was completely unaware of his suggestions as remedies for potentially racist language. His conversation with Stacy did not mention race, and the tone of their conference might have been completely different had he chosen to pursue such discussion. Had Meredith not seen the potential for conflict in her conference with Liz, she may have glossed over her race paragraph and left Liz with distaste for a program that apparently didn't value diverse expression. Liz had complained about her professor's apparent dislike for her original ideas; if she and Meredith had not arrived at common ground for revision, it may have been received poorly, further perpetuating misunderstanding. Alertness for contact zones cannot be taught to every student, but Fellows have many opportunities to instill comprehension of their benefits in those they tutor, provided they are aware of how and when they play out.

While the discourses of racism are centuries-old, deeply and often invisibly ingrained in the American psyche, potential for small but meaningful change exists in university institutions. Creating a welcoming atmosphere in the writing conference is integral to the mission of reinventing the Writing Center and the Undergraduate Writing

Fellows Program as allies of minorities in a university that truly values diversity but cannot always prevent their alienation. The uncomfortable nature of contact zones exemplifies the fact that dealing with racism and prejudice will be difficult before it is easy, but the benefits it provides tutors and students can easily outweigh the risks.

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